My Quiet Neighbor

By Ira Brodsky and Barbara Lhota

CHARACTERS
MILLIE, mid 40s, a quiet, purposeful woman
CELESTE, late 40s, Millie's rather wild neighbor

(Millie faces the audience. She carries a box.)

MILLIE: *(To audience.)* The ad for my condo building read "Safe, secure, quiet building occupied by single mature adults." It sounded perfect for me.

CELESTE: *(Yells out.)* Hey neighbor!

MILLIE: *(To audience.)* But it wasn't.

CELESTE: I got a giant blow-up Santa for the front yard and this elf guy that flops over in the wind and flashes you his striped skivvies!

MILLIE: Celeste was not quiet, secure, or adult. In fact, if you called her any of those things, she'd probably smack you.

CELESTE: The condo committee will love it!

MILLIE: *(To the audience.)* They wouldn't. Trust me. Though none of the neighbors spoke out loud about it, we all knew that Celeste single-handedly brought down our property values by 23 percent.

CELESTE: Hi, honey! Welcome! *(Singing.)* "Consider yourself at home! Consider yourself part of the family!" *(Encouraging her.)* You know it. Join in!

INTRODUCTION

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CELESTE: Well, don't just stand there with the box in the hand. *(Reaching out.)* Put it down and give your new neighbor a big bear hug.

MILLIE: Oh. I uh

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CELESTE: *(Hugging Millie.)* Come on, I don't have any lice. Now. *(Laughs.)*

MILLIE: *(Scratches her hair discreetly.)* Oh.

CELESTE: Got 'em from volunteering at the homeless shelter.

MILLIE: *(To audience.)* Did she volunteer or live there?

CELESTE: So why the change of locale? Leaving your husband?

MILLIE: What? No, I-what made you think

CELESTE: You look very healthy and flush. They say single women are more healthy.

MILLIE: Well, I'm not married, but I think the flush thing is just sweating.

CELESTE: Then I was right to order that pizza. To keep up your strength. I gave them your buzzer.

MILLIE: Pizza?!

CELESTE: Don't get your panties in a jam. I'll pay you back.

MILLIE: Oh, no. Panties aren't-jammed. *(To audience.)* Who is this person?

CELESTE: He's a cute delivery man. You'll like him.

MILLIE: But it's only ten AM!

CELESTE: *(Confidently.)* It's never too early for pizza.

MILLIE: Well, I better get back to work.

CELESTE: Oh! *(Hands her something.)* A present from your new neighbor.

MILLIE: Thank you. *(Looking at it.)* That's so . . . Dryer sheets?

CELESTE: I know. Most new neighbors welcome you with cookies or a fruit basket. But I don't know if you're a diabetic or hate bananas. But you gotta do laundry-am I right?!The box is open, but I only used one sheet. Then my dryer died. You don't mind if I use yours later?

MILLIE: Oh, that's fine.

CELESTE: So where are you from?

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MILLIE: Harper Woods. I lived with my mother. We had a big house, almost a mansion, and I loved it and I didn't marry and we got a long very well, and I don't think it's that strange at all!

CELESTE: I would've liked to stay with my mom too, but my stupid husband insisted I go with him. And then look what the stupid louse did!

MILLIE: Oh my. He divorced you?

CELESTE: No! He died. What an idiot!

MILLIE: Oh, I'm sorry.

CELESTE: Don't be. I'm furious with him. It was years ago now. Besides, he's with me all the time, messing things up as usual. . . He talks to me in my mind.

MILLIE: I've been busy helping my mother get settled into the nursing home. My mother has Alzheimer's so . . .

CELESTE: Ohhh. *(Beat. Patting Millie's back.)* Well, who doesn't?

MILLIE: What? *(To audience.)* I have no idea what possessed me. I hadn't even told my closest coworker at the bank. Of course, I'm not all that close with them. But her reaction was oddly perfect.

CELESTE: Who isn't getting Alzheimer's? I walk into a room, I came for something, forget what I came in for. Then forget I'm even in the room. Do you do that?

MILLIE: Well. . . I

CELESTE: Oh jeez. Stupid me. Speaking of forgetting. *(Puts out her hand.)* Celeste H. E. Raulster. The H. and E. stand for Holly Esther. Not to be confused with polyester, which is a cheap fabric and not my name. Not that I'm not cheap. You?

MILLIE: Uh, Millie.

CELESTE: No, not the name. Are you cheap?

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MILLIE: Uh, occasionally? *(To audience.)* Celeste drove me crazy. She didn't chat. She chewed your ear off. And when she was finished chewing, she spit it out and stomped on it. When she said she'd stop by for a short visit, the only thing short about it was the cash she had on hand to pay for the Chinese food she ordered sent to your buzzer.

CELESTE: *(Singing.)* Ming Wu, I love your crab Rangoon! Rangoon!

MILLIE: She played loud music and sang her own made-up lyrics to it full-voice at all hours and borrowed back dryer sheets, DVDs, and toilet paper she gave for presents. And worse, she frequently invited me to her cats' birthday parties-and just coincidently also invited weird single men, Melvin, Lewis, Bull, all whom she met at the local Donut Hole.

MILLIE: But more strange than this was that, somehow over the next year, *(Horrified.)* Celeste had actually become my friend. She even drove with me to see my mother quite frequently. Turns out, she had a real connection with

CELESTE: *(Driving the car.)* "Bingo! Bingo!" That rotten lousy wench starts screaming and waving her card around. She likes to be a big shot handling four Bingo cards at once, but you can't follow four cards. Not when you can't even remember your own address.

MILLIE: Poor thing.

CELESTE: Poor thing? She almost ran over me with her walker. She's a lunatic, very hostile! *(Honking, yelling.)* Move, ya lump of lard! Jeez, whatta, ya blind? He can't see it's green!

MILLIE: Well, maybe Bingo lady is a bit jealous. I saw you talking with her guy, Eddie.

CELESTE: That's not her guy. But he is cute, isn't he?!

MILLIE: Celeste! He's like eighty-three years old!

CELESTE: So!?

MILLIE: So! That's. . . not right!

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CELESTE: I've always liked older men.

MILLIE: That's not older. That's like wanting-Santa Claus!

CELESTE: Oh well. Santa's into your mom anyway. Didn't you see him sharing his rice pudding? So happy! Winky-winky.

MILLIE: *(Horrified.)* My goodness, Celeste! How do you get that from pudding?

CELESTE: What? It's not like your mother isn't attractive. And she won't kiss and tell.

MILLIE: *(Covering her ears.)* Ahhhhh. No need to hear! She's my mother!

CELESTE: Fine, fine. *(Pointing.)* They're remodeling Fred's Fruits.

MILLIE: *(Beat.)* Yeah. So. You really think he likes her?

CELESTE: Let's put it this way. Santa definitely has a twinkle.

MILLIE: I can't believe it. My mother has better luck at a nursing home than I have. .

CELESTE: Hey, you will. I can feel it. Let's have a girl's sleep over on Saturday. We'll draw up a dating plan.

MILLIE: A what?

CELESTE: It's a war, Millie. You need a strategy!

MILLIE: I'm busy that day.

CELESTE: It'll be fun. *(Beat.)* Did you say busy?! With what?

MILLIE: *(Startled.)* Well, yeah. My Aunt Robin. . . is lending me her cabin. I told you.

CELESTE: No. You didn't. Funny. Alone?

MILLIE: Well, that was generally the idea. Just cuz I wanted some peace and quiet.

CELESTE: And you're going alone?

MILLIE: Of course, alone. I need a little peace and quiet.

CELESTE: *(Pointed.)* I see.

MILLIE: I just want to catch up on my reading and meditating.

CELESTE: *(Hurt.)* Sure, you do. And just because I drive you every week to see Mom and to Fred's Fruits doesn't mean you owe me. I'm sure you need some private time.

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MILLIE: No, Celeste! It's not like that. I just figured you wouldn't want to spend a whole weekend in a cabin reading and sleeping and being quiet?

CELESTE: *(Loudly.)* Why the hell not?!

MILLIE: Well, for one, you are not particularly quiet!

CELESTE: *(Loudly.)* I'm quiet! *(Quietly.)* Sometimes.

MILLIE: When? *(Celeste lets out a sigh.)* I'm being serious. Here we'll be at this lodge with all these ski-wear guys around. You're not going to want to be restful and calm.

CELESTE: Fine. Sure. OK. I understand. You need a little down time.

MILLIE: Exactly. You'll come next time with me for sure.

CELESTE: Right.

MILLIE: Definitely. You're on.

CELESTE: Terrific. *(Begging.)* Oh come on! I'll be quiet, quiet, quiet, so quiet. Pleasy?

MILLIE: No. Not this time, Celeste. It's supposed to be a me weekend. For me! Not you!

CELESTE: OK. *(Beat.)*

MILLIE: *(To audience.)* We arrived at the cabin at noon.

CELESTE: Oh my God! *(Points.)* Look at that view!

MILLIE: Oh yeah. It's gorgeous!

CELESTE: Not that view. That one. The ranger with the tight green pants.

MILLIE: *(To audience.)* I suggested we walk up to the national park lodge through the woods. It was perfect. Hardly anyone was there-dead of winter, middle of the week. I settled into a deep-cushioned chair. The fireplace warmed my feet as *(Sighs.)* ummm, I began to read.

CELESTE: *(Returning.)* You wouldn't believe that hot chocolate! Real stuff!

MILLIE: Celeste, I'm-*(Gestures up with her book.)*

CELESTE: Oh. Right. *(Puts her hand to her lips.)* Shhhh. I'll be quiet. Maybe I'll snooze.

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MILLIE: Good idea.

CELESTE: I want to be all fresh for our date.

MILLIE: Date?!

CELESTE: Yeah. Shh. Just a couple of guys gonna take us skiing later.

MILLIE: Skiing?! No, Celeste. Read my lips, understand me. I want *(Does hand gestures mocking sign language.)* quiet!

CELESTE: OK. But who says they won't be quiet? They're Indians. The guy I set you up with seems like the brooding type.

MILLIE: Great. You set me up with a quiet Indian serial killer.

CELESTE: I said brooding, not murdering. And I meant they're from Indiana, not Indians. I don't know why I said that. I'm getting old.

MILLIE: Celeste, I just wanted peace and quiet.

CELESTE: So? We'll do that all day tomorrow before the party and all day before you ski. And you can even be quiet while you ski.

MILLIE: Not when you don't even know how to ski?! Sure, you can be all quiet until you go smacking into a pine tree.

CELESTE: Well then things would definitely get quiet.

MILLIE: And party? What party?

CELESTE: Just a couple people I invited for a Jacuzzi thing.

MILLIE: No Jacuzzi and no party! I draw the line at skiing.

CELESTE: Then you will ski?

MILLIE: If it will get you to leave me be for the rest of the weekend, I will.

CELESTE: OK, fabulous! Skiing it is!

MILLIE: *(To audience.)* It's funny. I'm not an outdoorsy person, but being with Celeste on the top of the hill gave me a new confidence.

CELESTE: *(Freaked out as she looks down the mountain with her skies on.)* Ahhhhhh!

MILLIE: *(Stumbling over on her skis.)* What?! *(Seeing.)* Ooooh. That is high.

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CELESTE: That isn't a bunny hill! There is nothing bunny about that!

MILLIE: It'll be fine. Just turn back and forth, like the instructor said.

CELESTE: That's easy for you to say. I'd rather go straight.

MILLIE: You can't! You'll fly! You'll pick up speed and whip up over the moguls.

CELESTE: Moguls? Moguls don't sound good. Since when do you know so much?

MILLIE: *(Smiling.)* Well, Jed, gave me a few pointers.

CELESTE: Oh my gosh! You like the Indian man. Who knew you'd like the brooding?

MILLIE: He's not Indian. He's from Indiana. And I don't know yet.

CELESTE: Whatever! You like him! That's great! I'm happy for you. Now let's get off the slopes because I'm wet and cold and I'm going to die on this pumped-up bunny hill!

MILLIE: That's ridiculous! It'll be fine. Just turn gently as you go down. Just practice.

CELESTE: *(Trying, but slipping about.)* Turn?! I can't even move.

MILLIE: Lean your weight, bend your knees like you're picking up a suitcase. *(Celeste tries, but gets a cramp in her back.)*

CELESTE: Ahhh! Now, this is why I buy suitcases with wheels! I can't do this.

MILLIE: You? Can't? These are words I hear emerging from Celeste's own mouth?

CELESTE: Come on, let's just go rest and read a good book in a big comfy chair.

MILLIE: I thought you wanted to ski?!

CELESTE: I thought you wanted to read?!

MILLIE: I did! But you dragged me here, we took a lesson, and now I want to ski down the bunny slope.

CELESTE: Fine!

MILLIE: It'll be fun. We'll count to three and just go.

CELESTE: Fine. Sure. It'll be fun. You count. We'll both go. Can't wait.

MILLIE: Great. One, two, . . . three. Push off! *(Millie starts but Celeste waits.)* Hey!?

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CELESTE: Don't worry. Pick up the suitcase! It'll be fun!

MILLIE: *(To audience.)* And it was actually. Because only two seconds later, a skier crashed into Celeste at the top of the hill, pushing her off the top of the bunny hill and plunging her quickly down the mountain.

CELESTE: Ahhhhhhhhhhhh! *(Enjoying for one second.)* MMmmm. *(Heading for a tree.)* Ahhhhhh!

MILLIE: *(To audience.)* When all was said and done, she had two large bruises, a refund on her ski rentals, and a couple of potential dates. One of which her husband, in her head, told her might be the one. She's a lucky lady. I guess I am too. *(Holding up her leg.)* I only broke one leg. And you can't believe how nice Jed has been to me. I think we might have something. Once Sunday rolled around, Celeste whimpered on the couch while I finally got to read. Except I couldn't concentrate because I was thinking about Jed.

CELESTE: Millie. I'm sorry. I really am.

MILLIE: What?!

CELESTE: I ruined it. This weekend has been terrible! A complete disaster!

MILLIE: *(Thinking of Jed.)* Not, complete.

CELESTE: You're hurt. You'll have to miss work. And we didn't have any quiet at all!

MILLIE: Well, it definitely was not at all what I expected.

CELESTE: I know. I know! And I know it's my fault. I'm a rotten, terrible

MILLIE: Thanks.

CELESTE: What? *(Beat.)* Did you say "Thanks"?

MILLIE: Yes. Thanks. For it all. Before I met you, the days were predictable, but now, nothing is ever quite how I expect. And you know what? It's been good. Really good.

CELESTE: Even though, you. . . broke your leg?

MILLIE: And met a man.

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CELESTE: Yeah, a quiet brooding man from Indiana. And I introduced you. What a friend I am!

MILLIE: You are actually. *(Celeste looks at Millie rather moved. Millie takes Celeste's hand.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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